



“There is a need for Indian contributors to solve indigenous problems. For instance, a while back, Mozilla Firefox had problems with printing in the Indic locale, and it required Indian contributors to step forward to fix the problem.”

Satish Mohan, director, software engineering,
Red Hat Software Services (India)

“Companies that use FOSS to build products ought to credit FOSS when advertising their products; this can help create a healthy awareness and prove the utility and widespread application of FOSS,” says Rai. Further, advocacy at the root level is also important. “The CBSE syllabus avoiding the explicit mention of proprietary products, and universities adopting/discussing FOSS topics, are some credit-worthy advocacy initiatives. Further, discussion and debates around ODF versus OOXML are healthy initiatives to improve advocacy,” says Mohan.

The role of the government

FOSS consumption in India is still restricted. The government can play a crucial role here. “The government has to be involved at the adoption, appreciation and contribution level in order to make India emerge as a FOSS hub. Not only should it become a large consumer, but it should also create a supportive environment through the right policies for FOSS companies to grow. We also need more FOSS projects to be initiated by the government (like the UK government, which has been instrumental in initiating FOSS projects),” says Bacche.

Others feel that just by becoming a large consumer, the government will help the Indian ecosystem mature. “The Indian government becoming a large consumer would be the ‘big bang’ for the FOSS community, because if you have a large consumer base like the government, it would automatically result in a heavy demand for FOSS developers. The ecosystem will figure out how to train them and gear them for the task, thereby fostering the Indian community. Just the implementation of a policy that mandates the use of FOSS in large government projects will spur the demand and consumption of FOSS,” says Kadavil. Rai adds, “By proactively using FOSS to cut costs and spread the reach of its services, the Indian government will not only generate revenues (for FOSS companies), but will raise awareness and hence the demand for FOSS products and services.”

Facilitators: connecting producers and consumers

Commercial and non-commercial entities that contribute by way of talent and ideas, and provide significant

resources in terms of hardware, networking, and other goods and services that are used in the process of software development, are very important for the FOSS ecosystem. They are needed to connect the producers and consumers, giving each of them a much-needed push. So how mature are Indian FOSS facilitators? With numerous efforts being made by FOSS vendors and educational institutes to collaborate—through conferences, virtual platforms and events, India has reached a certain maturity level—but there is always scope for improvement!

Educational institutions

Non-commercial entities like educational institutions play a crucial role as facilitators, as the use of FOSS in classrooms/production applications helps raise awareness, creates demand for FOSS products and processes, and develops the right talent pool. Besides this, educational institutions are the prime force in encouraging intellectual contributions back to the community.

“Academia makes considerable use of IT and hence should take the initiative to promote the use of FOSS, both at the network level, as well as among the students. They could begin by making the student/user machines dual-boot, and based on the comfort levels, move completely to FOSS,” says Bhavsar, who runs the entire network at ITM on FOSS tools—where all user machines, including student laptops, are dual-boot installations. “Exposing students at the university level to real-life FOSS projects is crucial. Educational institutions, in close association with the government (as large-scale users) and corporations can provide students such exposure,” adds Kadavil.

FOSS vendors

By getting together for the common good, whenever possible, FOSS solution providers can promote FOSS—pushing a unified message about what it stands for and the benefits it offers consumers. In addition, they often hire community members to work full-time on challenging projects. They play a crucial role in developing the ecosystem.